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RAMA KIRLOSKAR
Joint Managing Director,
Kirloskar Brothers

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Pumps and Precision

Rama Kirloskar is combining manufacturing precision with tech and AI for competitive advantage

BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**

RAMA KIRLOSKAR LOVES manufacturing. "I like that it is a very precise science. It needs a different kind of management style, one that percolates right to the bottom," says the fifth-generation Kirloskar scion, who is the Joint Managing Director of Kirloskar Brothers, a company associated with pump manufacturing.

Close to 40% of potable water in India is pumped through Kirloskar's range of products. "Practically all cities and municipal corporations use our pumps," says Kirloskar. Likewise, there is a stronghold in the market for pumping systems used in high-rise buildings. "One chooses a Kirloskar pump because we meet all the global standards when it comes to efficiency," she points out.

Several times throughout the conversation, Kirloskar talks about how technology and artificial intelligence (AI) are critical to her growth story. One gets the impression of speaking more to a tech CEO. Interestingly, Kirloskar does not come from a technology background. Armed with a degree in Mathematics and Biology from Bryn Mawr College in Pennsylvania, she first worked for Polaris Partners and then at the Koch Institute at MIT. "I am not an engineer, and that helped since it allowed me to be a lateral thinker. It really comes down to application of knowledge from field to another," she says.

The initial years—starting in 2014—were spent in product portfolio management. As part of her initiation, she spent time at the company's foundries and factories. In mid-2016, her father, Sanjay Kirloskar, CMD of Kirloskar Brothers, sent her to Kirloskar Ebara, in which it owned a 45% stake.

Like many of her contemporaries in business, she is a firm believer in the India story. Clearly, the next few years will keep her extremely busy. BT

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NOTE *The rank is based on* BT*'s proprietary methodology involving profit after tax, profit growth, and operating profit margin, focusing on profitability as the key metric to judge performance*